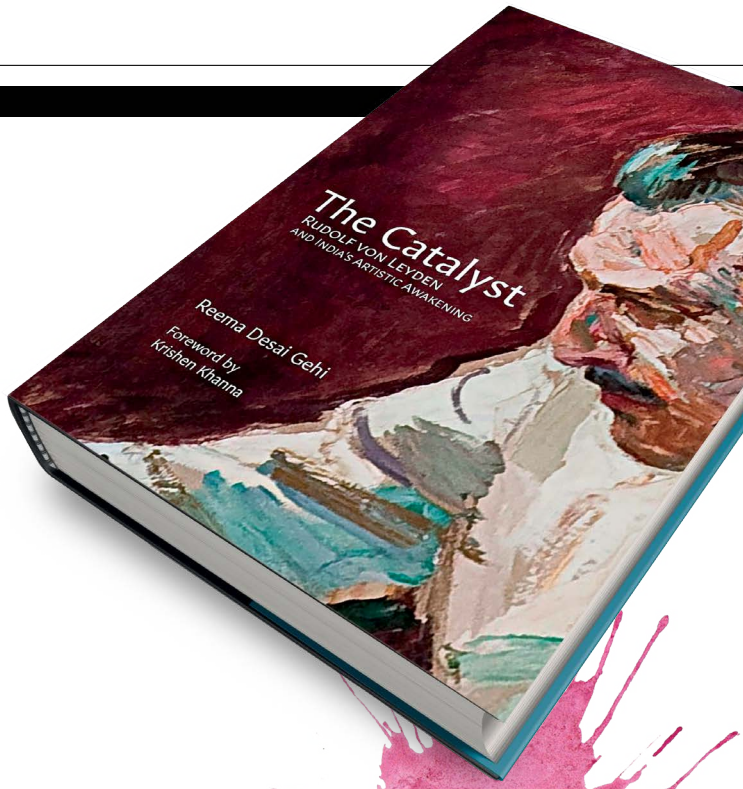
BOOKS

The Reluctant Art Critic

Advertising executive, art critic and possible catalyst of the modern Indian art movement, **Rudolf von Leyden** was an intriguing figure in pre-Independence Bombay



THE CATALYST
Rudolf Von Leyden And India's Artistic Awakening
by Reema Desai Gehi
SPEAKING TIGER
₹799; 216 pages

Open any book on modern Indian art of the 20th century and the name of Rudolf von Leyden will leap out. Along with him there are two others, Walter Langhammer and Emanuel Schlesinger, who arrive a little later in pre-War Bombay, fellow exiles fleeing the Armageddon of Nazi Germany.

Linked by their common passion

BOOKS

ARTS AND THE MAN

In his centenary year, ***F.N. Souza: The Archetypal Artist*** tries to make sense of the recurring themes in the artist's work

To give the publishers their due, the flap of the dust jacket gives you fair warning: "Be prepared to be shocked, bewildered and amazed. Beware—since most of Souza's art images overlap with your personal unconscious, you will be triggered. Everything you have repressed and rejected will stare back at you in full glory." In his 'Introduction', art historian Debashish Banerji continues the heads-up mode: "Undoubtedly, the bulk of this book is devoted to Souza's depictions of women and sex."

Already slightly breathless, the reader turns to the book itself. In Section 1, 'FN, the Feminist Artist', there are many paintings of naked women, or perhaps the same, unchanging naked woman; over decades, uninterrupted by any other, the one kind of body type, with large breasts, narrow waist and large buttocks, that Souza feels he has to paint again and again. In case we make the mistake of interpreting these paintings as stemming from a tediously phallocratic gawp-gaze that red-

In case we interpret Souza's nudes as stemming from a phallocentric gawp-gaze, Singh brings us back to the correct path